

January 2, 2026.

Happy New Year, Kenyon

I have finally been able to read your chapter on Peru and learnt so much from it. I simply had no idea of the Putomayo genocide and the operations of the rubber industry there....as the many exclamation marks show! I like in particular your descriptions and analyses of racism.

In general, as it stands it is much too descriptive and needs to be more analytical. Taussig is helpful, certainly but I think looking at the issue globally, other aspects need to be brought in.

This could be done in several ways. For instance, at about the same time as the atrocities were being committed against the indigenous populations by the Peruvian Amazon Company, the Belgians in the Congo were also brutalizing Africans in the rubber industry (see *King Leopold's Ghost*). Can this be theorized?

Bringing in people from Barbados—as enforcers especially—that is to say people from a jurisdiction controlled by another power is an interesting twist. Also note though (and of course the brutality was largely absent), sugarcane planters in Hawai'i brought Portuguese to be labor supervisors to the plantations there. There is a literature on colonial overlords bringing subordinate peoples from another area to be a layer between them and the colonized (Indians in East Africa). Did the strategic importance and/or natural characteristics of the crops, social structures in the peripheries/edges of empires have anything to do with the different patterns of labor control?

Another aspect that needs to be discussed theoretically is the issue of “production and consumption [being] mediated through exchange” (pp. 27-34). One argument Wallerstein and others make is that capitalism will come to an end if the capitalists have to provide fully for the reproduction of the labor force; that much of the reproduction costs are borne by the households (small family plots, informal labor, extended families rearing children, etc) and therefore most people are part-lifetime proletarians. This of course does not apply to the situation here because they are working them to death—not even providing food the the long marches. But that

does not apply to the Barbadians to the same extent. How does all this fit with say, the Congo?

On another matter: there needs to be some discussion about the nature of the Peruvian Amazon Company—its structure, what say, was its relations legally and otherwise with “Columbian rubber agents” (p. 18).

Minor points:

- Pp. 1-2: labor system not as ‘pre-capitalist’ or ‘non-capitalist’....see Jairus Banaji’s “Modes of Production in a Materialist Conception of History” in *Capital & Class* (I think 1977) and reprinted in his *Theory as History*
- P. 13: “colonial hegemony”—perhaps rephrase
- It would be helpful to the reader, perhaps even as a footnote, to say something about the border between Peru and Colombia and the treaty/agreement of 1927.
- P. 35: meatpacking in Chicago...perhaps not for this chapter, but see *Devil in the White City*.

I attach a lightly marked up version of your text

Let’s talk when you have the time and hope you had a good break.

Best

Ravi